

Episode 55: Once Upon a Time... (36) – Do Rising Spirits Soar Through the Heavens? *Tenjou-hen Uchuu Kouji* Part 4

The other day, I ended up making a "click" purchase. A pretty expensive purchase at that. Oh, not a computer. A camera. A digital camera. I bought another one.

It's a SIGMA DP-1 compact digital camera, and it's great! A high-performance lens without zoom and a large CCD for digital SLR cameras. Man, what a niche item.

I'm itching to take this somewhere for photography. Ah, I want to travel! Preferably overseas! Even if not overseas, I want to go on a trip somewhere regional! Tonight I'll jump on a late-night bus and tomorrow be in Tohoku? Shikoku? Kyushu?

But precisely when I feel like this, work gets busy. Or maybe I end up buying cameras as a reaction to being busy? (bitter laugh)

Either way, it's rainy season. The weather's been consistently bad... But rainy landscapes could be quite interesting as subjects...

...Well, I'm in the middle of the usual frantic mode (bitter laugh).

Well then.

After spending about 3 weeks during the humid rainy season in a clean, comfortable hospital room surrounded by young, beautiful nurses (!), I returned to the front lines with renewed energy starting from episode 6. However, I couldn't immediately go 100% full throttle, so I had someone else handle finishing inspection for episode 7, which was worked on parallel to episode 6. But from then until the final episode 13, I was able to handle everything myself solidly.

Starting with *Saint Seiya*, I had handled several TV series, but this was my first time being continuously assigned colour direction for each episode like *Tenjou-hen Uchuu Kouji*. My enthusiasm grew with each episode, and more and more ideas and things I wanted to try kept emerging. Colour direction meetings became enjoyable around this time too.

Oh no, they were enjoyable before too (laugh), but instead of just receiving "please do this" from directors, I started actively proposing ideas and expressing opinions myself.

That's because, as I wrote before, *Tenjou-hen Uchuu Kouji* had relatively few members rotating solidly through direction, animation, art, photography, and colour direction, so I unconsciously felt a "team" atmosphere or sense of trust and unity. That's why the more I actively engaged, the better it was received and became even better, creating that kind of flow.

Additionally, especially the animation staff, with competitive spirit against other episode "teams" beyond their own assignments, kept raising quality higher and higher. This kind of elevation is great (laugh).

As an aside, at that time Kadokawa Shoten was simultaneously producing an OVA of the novel "Record of Lodoss War" (production by Madhouse) similar to *Tenjou-hen Uchuu Kouji*. With similar schedules producing and releasing all 13 episodes, this *Record of Lodoss War* became a huge hit.

However, the production situation was apparently quite tight, with repeated "release date postponements." But when it was released, it sold incredibly well.

Meanwhile, ours never improved in sales and seemed quite in the red financially. The Kadokawa producer was holding his head. There was even bitter laughter about "making *Tenjou-hen Uchuu Kouji* with *Record of Lodoss War* profits" (bitter laugh).

I actually owned all those *Record of Lodoss War* LDs (laugh).

For writing about *Tenjou-hen Uchuu Kouji* this time, I actually dug up the LD deck from my parents' house and reviewed everything. Equipment that hadn't even been plugged in for years, just gathering dust under the TV (laugh). I carried it by hand on the train and set it up at home. Naturally I brought the software too, but since they're 30cm diameter discs, they were incredibly heavy (bitter laugh).

So I nervously tested it and played them back. The LD software's outer vinyl bags had deteriorated, crumbling into powder-like pieces every time I touched them (laugh). I captured that to computer and made movie data that I'm still watching while writing (laugh).

Watching continuously, I could clearly see how we really tried all sorts of things episode by episode. Special colouring patterns that felt somewhat exploratory in early episodes became increasingly elaborate toward the latter half, with more comfortable scenes that perfectly matched the animation tension. Also trying small techniques with various coloured carbons like brown, white, and blue, and adding colour changes within single cuts—we probably tried every conceivable idea at the time and enjoyed it.

Like with the previous Toei Video OVAs, reviewing my own old work has an embarrassingly ticklish quality, but *Tenjou-hen Uchuu Kouji* is rather enjoyable because I can see "working so happily (laugh)."

All 13 episodes made over about 2 years (come to think of it, there was also a theatrical re-edit compilation of about the first 7 episodes). It was a fun, satisfying period. After finishing the final episode, I secretly hoped for continuation series or more adaptations, but unfortunately that opportunity never came (bitter laugh).

While juggling multiple concurrent projects at the time, I feel this was a work where I could create very fulfilling. At the same time, it was a work where I can now say "Ah, I grew quite a bit (laugh)."

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